ahead with the blockade. “I ask you to recognize clearly, Mr. Chairman, that it was not I who issued the first challenge in this case, and that in the light of this record these activities in Cuba required the responses I have announced,” wrote Kennedy. “I repeat my regret that these events should cause a deterioration in our relations. I hope that your Government will take the necessary action to permit a restoration of the earlier situation.”[13]

Kennedy’s terse response pointed, in Khrushchev’s mind, in one direction, and one direction only: the Americans were preparing for military action. It was to target not only Cuba but also the Soviet Union. Global nuclear war was imminent—a matter of hours, not days. On the morning of October 24, Soviet military intelligence officers stationed at the Soviet embassy in Washington intercepted an order to Strategic Air Command (SAC) units to raise their Defense Readiness Condition (DEFCON) to level 2, just short of level 1, which was reserved for conditions of open warfare. Never before had US strategic forces been put on that level of alert. The fleet of 1,479 bombers and 182 ballistic missiles, with 2,962 nuclear warheads at their disposal, was getting ready to strike targets in the Soviet Union.[14]

The DEFCON order was implemented at 10:00 a.m. EST on October 24, the same day and time as the naval blockade of Cuba. A few minutes later General Thomas S. Power, the tough-talking commander in chief of SAC, went to a microphone and spoke over unprotected communication lines to his staff, scattered across dozens of military bases and bunkers throughout the world. “This is General Power speaking,” he began. “I am addressing you for the purpose of reemphasizing the seriousness of the situation the nation faces. We are in an advanced state of readiness to meet any emergencies, and I feel that we are well prepared.” Power had the president’s authorization to raise the level of alert, over unprotected communication lines, but he had no authority to address his troops in the same manner. Apparently, that did not matter to him, but Kennedy was losing his monopoly on communicating with Khrushchev. The military was opening its own hotline with the Soviet Union.[15]

Whether the text of Power’s address was intercepted and delivered to Khrushchev or not, Soviet military intelligence intercepted the Joint Chiefs of Staff order of October 24 to SAC to raise its DEFCON to level 2. Soviet